

Witsuwit'en literacy training 2019

Overview of Witsuwit'en writing system

Each distinctive sound in the Witsuwit'en alphabet is spelled with its own symbol or combination of symbols. The symbols used in the Witsuwit'en writing system are the same as those used to write English, because of widespread literacy in English and familiarity with English language computers.

Consonants

Witsuwit'en has more distinctive consonants than English does, so to spell all of the Witsuwit'en consonants, some consonant sounds are spelled with two or three symbols. These are the consonant symbols of the Witsuwit'en alphabet:

' b c c' d dl dz g gg gh gw h k k' kh kw kw' l lh m n p s t t' ts ts' tl tl' w wh y yh z

<i>consonant</i>	<i>example</i>	
'	tse'alh	pillow
b	bin	lake
c	cas	grizzly
c'	ilc'oh	he's going along mad
d	diz	driftwood
dl	dildlit	he/she is talking in a loud, angry voice
dz	dzut	coat
g	gis	hook
gg	ggis	spring salmon
gh	c'ighih	roots
gw	gwe'ilh	bag
h	halho'	cloth
k	kë	foot
k'	k'a	ammunition, shells
kh	khikh	goose
kw	kwin	fire
kw'	kw'isil	bead
l	lëggoc	chicken
lh	lhës	bread, bannock
m	min	roof
n	nu	island
s	sis	black bear
t	tiz	cane
t'	t'alh	food
tl	itloh	he/she is laughing
tl'	tl'olh	rope
ts	tsa	beaver
ts'	ts'ac	bowl, plate

w	niwis	soapberries
wh	'awh	around, off to the side (there)
y	yin	land
yh	'ayh	snowshoe
z	zī	belt

Vowels

English has only five symbols to represent vowels, and since there are more than five vowel sounds in Witsuwit'en,¹ it is also necessary to combine symbols to represent each vowel sound in a unique way. Two of the vowel symbols used to write these sounds consist of a primary vowel symbol, **i** or **e**, marked with " (called 'umlaut' or 'dieresis') over the vowel.

ī ē ü o a i

Here are some examples of the vowel symbols used to spell Witsuwit'en words:

	<i>Witsuwit'en example</i>	<i>Closest sound in English</i>
ī	dzin 'day', bīt 'inside', mbī 'who', Kw'īs (chief name)	ski, bleed, breathe, piece, receive, she, amoeba, highly
e	dzen 'muddy water', tsen to 'sweat', ndet 'it's narrow'	weigh, they, way, ache, detain, gauge, great
ē	t'ēt 'teenage girl', tl'ēt 'night', lhēs 'flour, bread, bannock'	led, tread, says, said, guest, Thames
u	dzut 'coat', ku 'puppy', lhk'u 'different; smart'	Lucy, Ruth, true, to, too, two, uncouth, stew, pseudo
o	to 'water', ts'o 'spruce'	more
a	t'alh 'food', skak 'child'	father
i	tin 'ice', bin 'lake'	other, medicine

Three of the vowels, **o**, **a**, and **i**, have fairly different pronunciations depending on what the neighboring consonant is. It should be kept in mind that this is a fact about the oral language. The writing system simply tries to reflect or represent as accurately and clearly how the language is pronounced. These vowels will be discussed in much more detail below

There are also long versions of six of the Witsuwit'en vowels:

īī ee ēē uu oo aa

¹Witsuwit'en actually has fewer distinctive vowels than the English spoken in North America, but the English writing system does a particularly poor job of representing the vowel sounds in English. The pronunciation of English has changed in 600 years but the spelling has not kept up with all the changes. Many of the spellings of English words represent the way those words were pronounced roughly 600 years ago. Spellings like *ea*, *ie* represent original diphthongs; *ee* and *e* represented an original vowel length contrast.

History of the Witsuwit'en writing system

The 'distinctly Witsuwit'en' writing system was developed in 1991 by Sharon Hargus, and is based on the writing system for the Nadot'en/Nedut'en/U'in Wit'en (also known as Babine) dialect of the language, which was developed by Hank Hildebrandt in consultation with Dick Walker and Gillian Story. The Witsuwit'en writing system was presented at a March 1993 meeting of the hereditary chiefs, and after much discussion, summarized in Jim 1999, the chiefs voted to adopt the revised system as the official Witsuwit'en writing system. A series of literacy workshops to provide training in the Witsuwit'en writing system were held in Moricetown between 1993-2000.

The main differences between the Nadot'en and Witsuwit'en systems involve the following points:

	<i>Hildebrandt system</i>	<i>revised Hildebrandt</i>	
(1)	negizjee	neggizgī	'fox'
(2)	whenicljit	wenigilgit	'I'm scared'
(3)	yeilhdic	yeelhdic	'they're talking'
(4)	seezee	sīzī, sezī	'Jesus'
	weusdleet	weusdlīt, weuslīt	'it's not melting'
	sitl'eet	sitl'et	'he farted'
	sidlet	sidlet	'it's licking me'
	tl'et	tl'ēt	'night'
(5)	dijuwh	diguh	'mosquito'
	widzeeyh	widzih	'caribou'
(6)	bi'n	bin'	'morning'

(1) j is used in Nadot'en but not Witsuwit'en; g represents a different sound in Nadot'en than it does in Witsuwit'en

(2) -icl- is used in Nadot'en but -igil- in Witsuwit'en in certain verb forms

(3) the long vowels are represented as vowel+i in Nadot'en

(4) the Witsuwit'en vowels ī ē ē are represented differently in Nadot'en

(5) the symbols wh and yh are used more in Nadot'en than in Witsuwit'en

(6) Witsuwit'en n' and m' are spelled 'n and 'm in Nadot'en

Point (1) involves an actual phonetic difference in the oral language between the two dialects, but the other points simply reflect differences in decisions about the design of the writing systems.

There are now various written works in the Witsuwit'en writing system, including Gottesfeld 1991, Hagwilget Band 1995, Gunlogson 1995, Hargus 1999, Gunlogson 2001 and various unpublished materials developed for Kyah Wiget Education Society, Moricetown, such as Morris and Rosso 1999. The forthcoming dictionary will also be written using this writing system. A set of materials was developed for a UNBC course, FNST 131 and 132, Witsuwit'en language courses offered in Moricetown through UNBC in 1997, 1998, 1999, 2000. These courses were co-taught by George Holland, Lillian Morris, and Sharon Hargus, who developed the materials together. In 2000, a set of audio recordings was made and hyperlinked to these

materials, and distributed by Kyah Wiget Education Society as a CD (Hargus 2000), viewable with an internet browser such as Microsoft Internet Explorer.

LH

Lh is an important sound of Witsuwit'en and other First Nations languages, not found in English. It is easy to learn to say properly, although English speakers without training tend to imitate this as kind of a "th-l" sound. (Example: The city of Seattle is named after the Lushootseed Chief Seattle. His name would have been spelled **Si'alh** in the Witsuwit'en writing system. There are lots of objects named after Chief Seattle but spelled "Sealth" (school, ferry).)

Examples of LH

lhës 'flour, etc.'
lhëz 'ashes, dirt'
'alha' 'correct'
c'ilhtiy 'gun'
lhalhde' 'yesterday'

LH vs. L

'ilh 'dam'
lhic 'dog'
lhit 'smoke'
lhay 'many (objects)'
lhëtl'is 'mud'
yilhc'ilh 'it bit him/her'
lhisiye 'he/she walked by, through'
lhiyil 'it's white'

'il 'conifer branch'
bilic 'his/her dog'
bilit 'its smoke'
hiley 'there are many of them (people)'
letl'is 'soap'
yilhc'il 'he/she broke it'
lisible 'rosary'
liyap, liyap 'devil'

LH vs. S

lhay 'many (objects)'
lhis 'wood chip, small stick'
lho 'glacier'
lhokh 'round whitefish'
lhk'iy 'one'
t'alh 'food'
lhic 'dog'

say 'sand'
sis '(black) bear'
so 'frost'
sokh 'robin'
sk'iy 'my hip'
yit'as 'he/she is cutting it'
sic 'I myself', as in:
 sic 'isleg'h/'isdlegh 'I myself did it'
silh 'with me', as in:

lhilh 'with each other', as in:

lhilh 'aat'ah 'they're working with each other' silh 'aat'ah 'they're working with me'

O vs. U

Examples of u

Remember that the sound of Witsuwit'en **u** is similar to the sound of *u* in English *June*, *Ruth* or *Lucy*.

Except within loan words, *u* mostly occurs at the beginning of a word or after these consonants:

b	d	dz	dl	g	gg
m	n	z	l	y	gh

nu 'island'
 yu 'medicine'
 yut, nyut 'yonder'
 dus 'cat'
 dzut 'coat'
 gguh 'deadfall'
 uzi 'name'
 uye 'shy'

Examples of o

The Witsuwit'en vowel **o** has two different pronunciations. (1) When **o** follows any of these consonant sounds:

b	d	dz	dl	g	gw	gg
m	n	z	l	y	w	gh

o is pronounced like the underlined vowel in the following English words:

no, road, doughnut, zone, toe, slow, faux

nīdo 'white person'
 no'ilh 'glass'

o is relatively rare after the sounds listed in the above table. The examples above both appear to be loan words.

(2) When **o** follows any of these consonant sounds:

p	t	ts	tl	c	kw	k	
	t'	ts'	tl'	c'	kw'	k'	'
		s	lh	yh	wh	kh	h

The vowel **o** is pronounced like the vowel in *more*:

to 'water'
 ts'o 'spruce'
 so' 'well, fine'

k'on	'fish eggs, roe'
lho	'glacier'
lhot	'scab'
lhok	'fish'

O also has that same sound before **k** or **kh**:

talok	'sockeye'
Hagwilokhs	Likhts'amisyu chief name

Question: apply the two rules above to determine how to pronounce the following word:

doso	'gunny sack'
------	--------------

U vs. O

Compare **u** vs. **o** in the following words:

buzi' 'his/her/its name'	sozi' 'my name'
dus 'cat'	doso 'gunny sack'
c'izu' 'good'	so' 'well, nicely'
yuntan 'he/she is holding it'	ts'ontan 'we're holding it'
yunkët 'he/she bought it'	ts'onkët 'we bought it'
liglu 'nail'	liglos 'bell'
kayus 'horse team'	limiyos 'haystack, hayroll'
libuday 'bottle'	libot 'cup'

I vs. A

Examples of I

I could be the most challenging letter of the Witsuwit'en alphabet. The sound of **i** depends on what consonant sounds are next to it. There are five ways of pronouncing the letter **i**.

(1) The vowel **i** is pronounced like the underlined vowel in:

medicine, about, the one, bottom, to suspect

when this vowel follows any of the following consonants:

b	d	dz	dl	gg
m	n	z	l	gh

b <u>i</u> n	'lake'
m <u>i</u> n	'roof'

dzilh 'mountain'
nis 'ahead'

(2) The vowel **i** is generally pronounced like the underlined vowel in:

other, under, ough, flood

when it follows these consonants (for **c'**, only in stressed syllables):

p	t t'	ts ts' s	tl tl' lh	c c'	gw kw kw' wh w	k k' kh	, h
---	---------	----------------	-----------------	---------	----------------------------	---------------	--------

sis 'black bear'
lhit 'smoke'
tsiz 'dry wood, firewood'
tin 'sheet of ice'
cis 'down feathers; hill, ridge'

Before **k kh** the vowel **i** also has this same sound

nik 'uphill'
yikh 'house'

(3) When the vowel **i** follows **g, y** (and **c'** in unstressed syllables) the vowel **i** sounds more like 'i' in English 'it':

nig^ui 'fear'
yⁱis 'snow'
c'ⁱidⁱ 'horn'

(4) Before **y** which begins the next syllable, the vowel **i** sounds more like 'i' in English 'ski':

biyez 'her son or daughter'
ts'iyetsic 'everything'

(5) Before **wh w**, the vowel **i** sounds more like the vowel 'o' in English 'know what?' but it is not as long as Witsuwit'en **o**. Examples:

nⁱwis 'soapberries'
lhdiw 'it cramped up'

Before **kw** at the end of a word, the vowel **i** also has this o-like sound:

nizdikw

‘it’s spherical, three-dimensional’

Question

How should the following words be pronounced? Which rule for the pronunciation of **i** applies in each case?

dic ‘well’²

dik, ndik ‘straight up’

lhim ‘chunk of ice’

Examples of a

The vowel **a** has two different pronunciations. (1) **A** is generally pronounced like the underlined vowel in:

hat, laugh

after the following consonants:

b	d	dz	dl	g c c’ y	gg gh
m	n	z	l		

dayi

gabun

Mali

lizas

Ndo Mali

‘church chief’

‘credit, mortgage’

‘Marlene, Marion’

‘angel’

‘Holy Mary’

or when the preceding or following consonant is **c** or **c’**:

cas

can

ts’ac

‘grizzly’

‘rain’

‘bowl, plate’

²dic, ’en ’alha’ ’itni ‘well, he’s right’

(2) The vowel **a** is generally pronounced like the underlined vowel in:

father, soft, caulk (but for some speakers, more like hat, laugh)

after the following consonants:

p	t	ts	tl	gw	k	
	t'	ts'	tl'	kw	k'	,
		s	lh	kw'	kh	h
				wh		
				w		

t'alh	'food'
tat	'3 times'
kwa	'again'
tsa	'beaver'
tsan	'excrement'
tl'as	'dress, pants'

I vs. A

To learners of Witsuwit'en, the vowels **i** and **a** may sound similar to each other when they occur after these consonants:

p	t	ts	tl	c	kw	k	
	t'	ts'	tl'	c'	kw'	k'	,
		s	lh	yh	wh	kh	h

But the sound of the **i** vowel is shorter than the **a** vowel. Compare the following:

siy 'I, me'	say 'sand'
k'iy 'birch'	k'ay 'now'
bitiy 'his/her trail'	bitay 'his/her paternal uncle'
cis 'down feathers; hill, ridge'	cas 'grizzly bear'
izlhiy 'horse'	lhay 'many (objects)'
sis co 'big black bear'	sas co 'wild carrot'
skiy 'my husband'	'et sikay 'it (plate) is there'
tl'it 'fart'	tatl'at 'headwaters'

Writing practice

_____	‘car’
_____	‘cloud’
_____	‘gaff hook’
_____	‘there, then’
_____	‘song’
_____	‘on the edge, over the edge’
_____	‘snare’
_____	‘sinew’
_____	‘up, straight’
_____	‘char, lake trout’ (also means ‘in it’)
_____	‘hillside’
_____	‘his/her nostril’

When you have finished, compare what you wrote with your neighbor and try to come to some agreement.

Answers to writing practice

ka	‘car’
yet	‘cloud’
sikh	‘gaff hook’
’et	‘there, then’
cin	‘song’
wegh	‘on the edge, over the edge’
bīlh	‘snare’
ts’ëkh	‘sinew’
dik	‘up, straight’
bīt	‘char, lake trout’ (also means ‘in it’)
wenin	‘hillside’
binic	‘his/her nostril’